the quality nor the competitive pricing to match China. Also, since all this activity is essentially driven by the private actors in the global marketplace, India may not be able to become an adequate substitute." The exceptions are niche areas like defence products that concern national security, where US companies may be willing to pay a premium to import from India rather than China. Also, rather than the retaliatory trade measures India responded with in Trump's first term, experts advise that we make concessions in some of the tariffs to accommodate the US. As an official experienced in such negotiations says, "We should not look to balance every trade deal, but look at the macro picture and see where we can do business. The Trump administration is pragmatic and will be happy to go in for a win-win deal."

Another likely area of friction is Trump's policy on migrants, especially illegal ones. While he will use the strong-arm measures he has promised to evict illegal migrants, even in his victory speech, he was forced to concede that he was not against legal migrants. It is not only South Americans who will feel the heat of Trump's crackdown on illegal migrants. There are a large number of illegal migrants—an estimated 725,000—from India as well, particularly from Punjab and Gujarat, who seek refuge in the US. Last year, the Biden administration deported over 1,100 of them back to India. Worse, Trump is also likely to further trim the number of H1B visas for non-immigrant workers, which is currently limited to 85,000 annually, a bulk of which are cornered by Indians. The second Trump administration is likely to withdraw the spouse's work permits and make rules for issuing such visas far more stringent. This could have a downside for Trump, though. Along with his restrictive trade policy measures, mass deportations are likely to cause price rise and inflation in the US, since it will become costlier to produce goods.

HOW INDIA MUST DEAL WITH TRUMP

For New Delhi, Trump's return does not evoke as much anxiety as it does in other world capitals. That is because, in the past two decades, India and the US have "overcome the hesitations of history", as Modi calls it, and forged a strategic partnership that has grown both in stature, depth and breadth. In his first term, Trump's trade antagonism towards China saw him view India as an Asian bulwark against Xi Jinping's aggressive ambitions. The Trump administration worked hard to put in place agreements that would make transfer of defence technology and equipment to India on par with its closest allies. It was Biden, though, who took India-US relations to an altogether higher level by not only clearing deals to sell state-of-the-art drones but also, in a first, permitting jet engine production in India. Biden and Modi also signed up for a major collaboration on critical and emerging technologies, including semi-conductor chips, artificial intelligence, quantum computing and wireless telecommunication. "The US and India," says Tellis, "have dipped their toes in high tech before deciding to swim together. What's important is that the embrace is not just of government but also between the two societies at the entrepreneurial and technological layers. We need to structure such opportunities for Indian and US entrepreneurs to explore other possible partnerships for the long term."



GETTY IMAGES

TRUMP'S SECOND COMING MAY NOT THROW UP ANXIETIES IN INDIA AS IT DOES ELSEWHERE. INDIA AND THE US HAVE OVERCOME THE 'HESITATIONS OF HISTORY', AS MODI CALLS IT, AND NOW HAVE STRONG STRATEGIC TIES

Experts, however, point out that there is no room for complacency and, given Trump's mercurial personality, urge India to work hard to stay on his right side. "It has to be a win-win situation," says an expert in dealing with India-US relations. "For that, both sides must realise the inevitability of India-US cooperation. For India, aspiring to be a developed nation by 2047, there is no better partner than the US. For Trump's mercantile approach, India, with its large middle-class market and talent pool, makes it important to continue engaging with it more closely for America's economic growth and for creating jobs." Another expert says that the key is for Trump to see India as a solution provider for all the major